1946 to 15 May 1948 [the date of the termination of the British Mandate!] *and who lost both home and means of livelihood as a result of the 1948 conflict. The descendants of Palestine refugee males, including legally adopted children, are also eligible for registration* (*as refugees).”*

The UN officials who formulated the definition of a Palestinian refugee took the liberty of inventing a new kind of human being—an eternal refugee, both him and his descendants, until the end of time. These officials saw it as being under their authority to make the State of Israel, too, a “debtor” for this insurance policy. The reasoning behind the definition was that the refugee problem would be only a temporary one because it was only a short matter of time before the Arabs would defeat the Jews and the refugees would all return to Palestine. This was also an attempt to define Israel as a debtor in all future negotiations, which would be conditional upon the Jews’ prior consent to allow the return of the refugees. This is how the term *right of return* was born.

UNRWA also granted itself the liberty of defining the lowest possible threshold imaginable for acceptance onto the Palestinian refugees’ “insurance policy”; anyone who lived at a certain point on the planet for less than two years, as well as their descendants and those adopted by them, would benefit from that policy until the end of time.

According to authoritative estimates, the number of Arabs living in the territory of the British Mandate before the outbreak of the War of Independence was between 1.3 and 1.4 million. Approximately 400,000 of them remained in the territory captured by the Jordanian Legion (the “West Bank”). About 150,000 were in the Gaza Strip, which was captured by the Egyptian army. (These figures include both the original inhabitants of these areas and those who moved or were transferred there during or as a result of the war.) Approximately 105,000 Arabs remained in the State of Israel, and this number increased to approximately 156,000 after Israel agreed to accept some 50,000 Arabs within the framework of family unification. These figures show that the number of Palestinians displaced from their homes in 1948 was between 600,000 and 750,000. In 2015, however, the “Palestinian refugee club” numbers about five million members, with the forecast for 2020 reaching six million!

In his book *The Birth of the Palestinian Refugee Problem, 1947–1949,* the historian Benny Morris emphasizes that the idea of a transfer never developed in the minds of Zionist leaders as a party platform or master